The conduct of every aspect of life is rule governed. Conformity to ***dharma*** through the performance of ritual and social duties prevents pollution by contaminating forces, and its neglect generates bad ***karma***.

Further reading: Olivelle 1999; O'Flaherty 1991

Dignaga (480–540 CE): Buddhist philosopher whose most important work is the *Pramana-samuccaya*.

Dignaga radically divorces sensory perception and thought involving concepts and words (which, using the word in a broad sense, he calls inference). Sensory perception never involves conceptualisation. Perception is direct experience of objective reality, which consists of a flux of unique, momentary particulars (***svalakshana***). Because they do not share any common features, they are indescribable. The categories (***padartha***) that the ***Nyaya-Vaisheshika*** realists claim to find in the world are imposed by our minds.

Conceptual thought (***kalpana***) and language deal in generalities (***samanya-lakshana***). Even simple concepts are at one remove from reality because there are no objective general features. They are, however, causally related to the realities and not just arbitrary fictional inventions. But there is a gap between how our minds work and the way things are. The map is not the territory. Thought and language are inseparable: conceptual thought is born out of language and language is born out of concepts. Conceptual construction is the interpretation of what is given by sensory impressions via proper names, words for general features (***jati***, ***samanya***), words for qualities (***guna***), words for actions (***karman***) and words for individual substances (***dravya***). Our minds group unique particulars together and we understand them as continuing objects bearing types of properties.